



provides a formal setting for your business, giving it a physical base from which to operate. Such spaces come at a cost, but there are options.

Using shared spaces

Shared workspaces, where basic equipment and services (such as internet access) are part of the rental package, are now widely available. These provide professional settings, where you rent space—sometimes a single desk and computer—for as long as required. They offer many of the benefits of a private office, without the maintenance and setup costs.

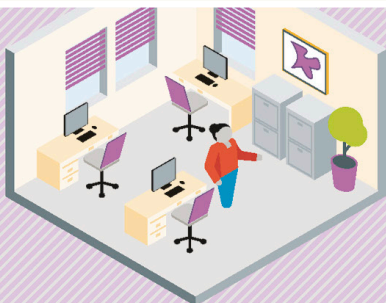
For some businesses, creating the impression of having a dedicated workspace is more important than having an actual physical space (see box, below right).

Storing and warehousing

Some businesses will need storage space on their premises to keep stock safe, dry, and secure and may need to rent additional storage space or warehousing. Self-storage is one option, but if products have to be shipped out to customers, you will have to find premises with sufficient room to accommodate inventory or rent warehouse storage space.

Warehousing can offer both storage and logistics (the inbound and outbound flow of goods, plus transportation and inventory control), but the costs may be high. Some distribution and fulfillment companies now provide flexible, cost-effective storage options, depending on how much you trade each season, where you pay only for the storage you use.

PRIVATE WORKSPACES



A private office outside your home puts you in control and gives you prestige, but it comes at a cost.

PROS

- **Private office space**, whether furnished and fully equipped or unfurnished, can be tailored to your needs.
- **You have privacy** and can control the work environment with fewer distractions than if you were home-based or worked in a shared space.
- **An office address** can offer more professional credibility and a place to meet clients.

CONS

- **The cost of overheads** when renting a private office space are much higher than for a virtual office or a home-based workspace.
- **The commute** may again take time out of your day and may add to your stress and costs.
- **Networking is not** as easy as when you operate from an open, community-based, coworking space.

VIRTUAL WORKSPACES

The cost of business premises can be one of the largest overheads for a small business, and start-ups may find renting office space unaffordable. One possible solution is a virtual office—a service that can offer start-ups credibility and many of the benefits of a physical office for a fraction of the cost. Entrepreneurs can work from home but use a telephone-answering service to manage calls, as well as reception services, and the option to book real meeting rooms when required. A virtual office can also offer a business address and mail-handling services to give a home-based company greater prestige.

66%
of companies begin in
a spare bedroom, garage,
or other part of the home

Entrepreneur Europe, 2020